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Roots and routes – A framework for Global Indian investors

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WS Global CIO Office

Two investor profiles, one shared opportunity

India's financial coming of age has created a generation of investors at a distinctive crossroads: deeply connected to one of the world's fastest-growing economies, yet increasingly aware that portfolios concentrated in a single market can accumulate risks over time.



This report discusses the challenges faced by two distinct '**Global Indian**' investor profiles. The first is the **onshore Indian investor**: a resident Indian whose wealth is largely denominated in domestic equities and fixed income, but who may still treat global markets as an occasional satellite allocation rather than a core portfolio component. The second is the **offshore Indian investor**: a non-resident Indian (NRI) based outside India with full access to global capital markets, yet who may be under-allocated to the growth story unfolding in their country of origin. Because global benchmarks understate India's economic importance, investors seeking more meaningful participation in its growth story may consider allocating above benchmark levels, with NRIs' potential stronger affinity with India providing an additional reason to make this adjustment.

For both groups, the starting point is the same: a concentrated bias towards either Indian or global markets can create risks that diversification can help mitigate without requiring investors to abandon their core convictions. For onshore Indian investors, global assets can provide structural currency diversification and access to sectors that are under-represented in Indian indices. Our Capital Market Assumptions (CMAs) illustrate the potential portfolio benefits: increasing the allocation to global assets from 0% to 15% raises expected returns while reducing expected volatility meaningfully. As a result, the portfolio's risk-adjusted returns improve.

For offshore Indian investors, India offers a real yield premium, a rising weight in global indices and long-term growth that remains meaningfully under-represented in global benchmarks. A historical perspective illustrates the opportunity: since 2001, Indian equities have delivered over 10% annualised returns in USD terms, outperforming Developed Market equities over the same period.

Onshore and offshore Indian investors may share the same connection to India, but they face very different portfolio challenges. There are key dividing lines that determine how each investor should think about diversification, risk management and the role of Indian assets within a broader investment portfolio.

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Base currency – the first and most important divide

The onshore Indian investor earns, spends, saves and ultimately retires in rupees (INR). Their relevant return is, therefore, an INR return. If the INR depreciates against the US dollar (USD), foreign assets rise in INR terms and can act as a natural hedge. If the INR appreciates, those same assets deliver lower INR returns than their local-currency performance would suggest. For the offshore investor, the currency problem is reversed. Their benchmark is typically USD-based, and Indian markets are the exposure that introduces exchange-rate risk. A strong year for Indian equities in INR terms may look less compelling once translated back into USD at an unfavourable exchange rate.

Regulatory access – different constraints, different routes

The onshore Indian investor operates within the Liberalised Remittance Scheme (LRS) framework. Depending on their circumstances, this can offer meaningful or constrained access to global markets. Fund-of-funds and international exchange-traded funds (ETFs) can also offer alternative access routes, as opposed to direct securities alone.

For the offshore Indian investor, the challenge is less about access to India than choosing the most appropriate investment route. They can generally invest through onshore accounts, while offshore-listed funds and ETFs may offer a more convenient alternative. The preferred structure will depend on their residency, tax domicile and product eligibility, making careful planning important even where access itself is relatively broad.

As an example, India's Gujarat International Finance Tec-City (GIFT City), home to the country's International Financial Services Centre (IFSC), is one potential implementation route available to both onshore and offshore Indian investors. For offshore investors, GIFT City offers an efficient way to access India-linked and global investment products with little or no need for INR conversion, while allowing foreign-currency repatriation. For onshore investors, it can facilitate USD-denominated exposure through foreign-currency accounts under the LRS, providing a domestically regulated, yet globally oriented platform for portfolio diversification.

Portfolio risk – concentration on one side, under-allocation on the other

The onshore Indian investor's core risk is concentration and complacency: a portfolio almost entirely exposed to India's domestic economic cycle, policy environment and sectoral composition. This is not a prediction that these will deteriorate, as India's structural growth story remains compelling. Rather, this implies the risk is structural when all equity exposure sits within a single market, causing the portfolio to react simultaneously to the same domestic catalysts. By contrast, the offshore Indian investor faces the opposite problem: under-allocation to one of the world's fastest-growing economies, driven partly by access frictions and partly by the difficulty of sizing a home-market allocation through a global investment framework.

Fig. 1

Risk profile breakdown between an Indian onshore investor vs a USD offshore investor

	INR onshore investor	USD offshore investor
Starting point	India-based investor whose wealth, spending and returns are primarily measured in INR	NRI whose portfolio benchmark is typically USD or another major currency
Currency lens	Foreign assets add currency risk, but can also hedge INR depreciation	Indian asset exposure adds INR risk; local returns can be reduced or bolstered when translated back to USD
Access route	Typically through LRS or family office structures	Typically use ETFs, Foreign Portfolio Investor (FPI) structures or the Fully Accessible Route (FAR)
Portfolio role	Indian assets remain the core; global assets diversify sector, cycle and currency exposure	Global markets remain the core; India is a deliberate growth and real-yield overweight
Core risk	Home-market concentration, domestic-cycle dependence and limited sector breadth	Under-allocation to India, INR volatility and operational complexity

Source: Standard Chartered

The building blocks of a Global Indian portfolio

A diversified portfolio makes sense regardless of the investor profile

Before examining the specific assets available to Global Indian investors, it is useful to step back and ask a more fundamental question: why hold multiple asset classes at all? The simple answer is diversification. Because different asset classes play different roles and perform differently across economic and market conditions, combining them thoughtfully can reduce risk, create more consistent outcomes and build greater portfolio resilience than relying on any single asset class alone.

Each major asset class tends to perform best under different economic conditions. Equities usually benefit when corporate earnings are growing and investor confidence is strong, but they can fall sharply when growth disappoints or credit conditions tighten. Bonds can provide income and may hold their value, or even appreciate, when growth slows and central banks ease policy, but they typically face pressure when inflation is high and interest rates rise. Gold has long been viewed as a geopolitical and inflation hedge, and its relatively low correlation with equities and bonds can make it a useful portfolio diversifier.

In practice, a portfolio concentrated in a single asset class – whether Indian equities, USD cash or any other standalone exposure – is implicitly relying on one set of economic and market conditions remaining favourable. A thoughtfully constructed multi-asset portfolio does not need to be the best performer in every year, but it is also unlikely to be the worst. Its purpose is to build resilience across market cycles: capturing growth when conditions are supportive, limiting

downside when stress emerges, and compounding steadily over time in a way that no single asset class can consistently achieve on its own.

A practical asset-class toolkit for Global Indian investors

Developed Market (DM) equities

These are typically shares in large, established companies across the US, Europe, the UK and Japan and usually represent the largest and most liquid equity markets in the world. They are home to the technology giants, global healthcare leaders and consumer brands that dominate their sectors globally – many of which have no equivalent in Indian indices. DM equities provide the broadest possible access to global corporate earnings growth, and for onshore investors, they provide USD and other major currency exposure that structurally helps hedge against INR depreciation. For offshore investors, DM equities are the natural portfolio core, given their base currency and broad exposure of the asset class in global markets.

Emerging Markets (EM) equities

EM equities span a broad universe of developing economies, including China, South Korea, Taiwan, Brazil and other major EM markets. They offer greater growth potential than DM equities, but also tend to be more volatile. Their returns are supported by rising consumption, commodity cycles and the expansion of industry and the middle class. For Indian investors, EM equities provide exposure to regional peers that behave differently from Indian domestic markets, adding a layer of diversification within the equity sleeve.



Indian equities

Indian listed equities can be split up into two distinct sub-asset classes: 1) small- and mid-cap equities and 2) large-cap equities. The latter represent India's established blue-chip companies with strong balance sheets and have relatively lower volatility within the Indian equity spectrum. These are typically the anchor of any Indian equity allocation. Meanwhile, small- and mid-cap equities tap into a different part of India's growth story: the domestic consumption engine, the formalisation of the informal economy and the entrepreneurial mid-market that scales rapidly in a high-growth environment. They offer meaningfully higher potential returns, but also comes with higher volatility and lower liquidity, making the appropriate allocation dependent on the investor's risk tolerance and investment time horizon.

DM Investment Grade bonds

Developed market investment grade bonds encompass two closely related asset classes that play a core defensive role in portfolios. Government bonds, such as US Treasuries, German Bunds, and UK Gilts, are issued by highly rated sovereigns and are widely regarded as the closest equivalent to a risk-free asset within global markets. Investment grade corporate bonds, issued by financially strong companies rated BBB- or above, offer higher yields than government bonds in return for accepting a modest amount of credit risk.

Together, these assets provide an important source of portfolio stability. Government bonds have historically performed well during periods of economic uncertainty and market turbulence, helping to cushion equity losses when investors seek safer assets. Investment grade corporate bonds enhance overall income generation while maintaining relatively low volatility, allowing investors to improve return potential without taking on the higher risks typically associated with equities.

EM USD bonds

EM USD bonds are USD-denominated debt issued by EM sovereign and quasi-sovereign borrowers, including countries such as Indonesia, Mexico, Brazil and South Africa. Their USD denomination removes direct exposure to the issuers' local currencies, making them a more accessible entry point into EM fixed income than local-currency bonds, particularly for offshore investors with hard-currency liabilities. For onshore investors, EM USD bonds add hard-currency fixed-income exposure and can diversify portfolios concentrated in Indian equities and INR interest-rate risk. However, their returns still depend on global interest rates, credit spreads and investor risk appetite.

India government bonds

The Indian bond market offers something that is increasingly rare globally: a genuine positive real (net-of-inflation) yield. India's 10-year government bond yielded around 6.7% in mid-2026 against a headline inflation of about 4.4%. This represents a positive real yield of nearly 2.8% that compares favourably to most DM alternatives. India's inclusion in global bond indices is now also channelling systematic passive inflows into this market, providing an additional structural demand tailwind.

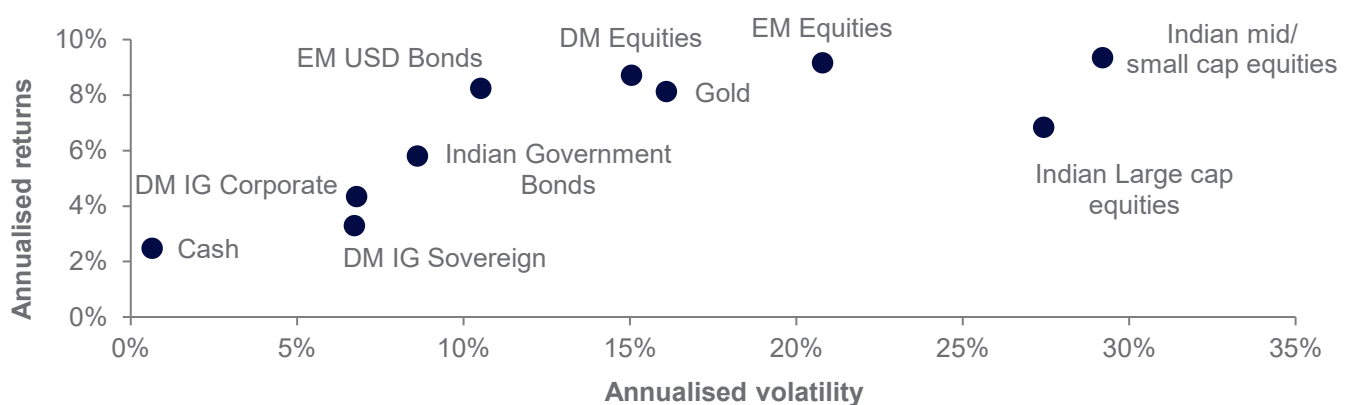
Gold

Gold occupies a unique role in this framework particularly for Indian investors. Beyond its universal function as an inflation and geopolitical hedge, gold in INR terms has historically delivered strong returns during periods of INR weakness because gold prices are globally denominated in USD. When the INR depreciates, the INR value of gold rises, providing a natural cushion against the same currency dynamics that erode domestic purchasing power.

Fig. 2

Comparing asset class risk and return since 1995*

Risk-return spectrum of asset classes in USD



Source: Bloomberg, Standard Chartered

Data as of 31 August 2026

* Data for DM IG Corporate bonds from Oct 2000; data for Indian Government Bonds from Jan 1999; data for EM Equities from Jan 2001

Why an India-only portfolio may not be enough

The case for global exposure for onshore Indian investors – Most resident Indian investors already diversify across asset classes, typically holding a mix of equities, fixed income and, in some cases, commodities such as gold. However, this diversification is usually implemented through domestic assets. The gap, therefore, is not necessarily a lack of asset-class breadth, but a lack of geographic diversification. This is where global investing can play an important role: by adding exposure to different economies, currencies, sectors and market cycles beyond India.

Argument

01

The INR depreciates structurally

Since India's market liberalisation in the early 1990s, the INR has depreciated significantly against the USD, weakening from approximately INR 31 per USD in 1994 to more than INR 95 per USD by August 2026 – an annualised depreciation rate of 3.4%. This long-term depreciation is not simply a market fluctuation; it reflects a structural feature of an economy that has persistently run higher inflation than the US. For investors holding only INR-denominated assets, this creates a gradual erosion of global purchasing power over time. USD-denominated foreign assets can, therefore, serve as a structural currency hedge, helping preserve international purchasing power rather than representing a speculative currency bet.

Fig. 3

Decades of INR depreciation against USD highlight the currency risk embedded in India-only portfolios

INR/USD exchange rate since 1994



Source: Bloomberg, Standard Chartered
Data as of 31 August 2026

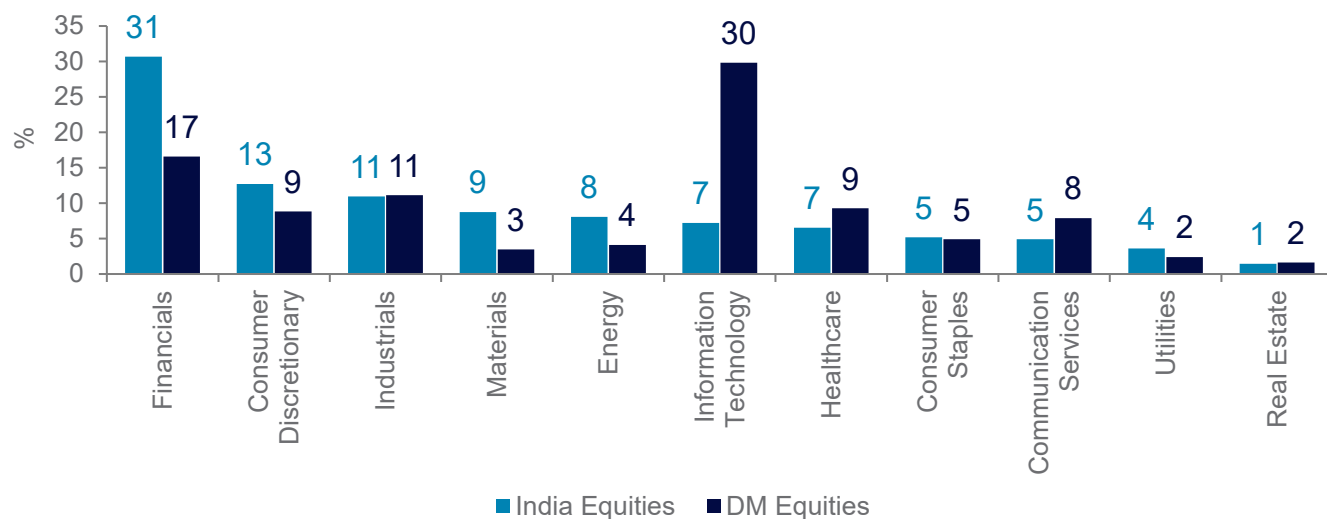
Sector gaps in Indian equity markets

Indian equity indices remain heavily weighted towards the financial, consumer discretionary and industrial sectors. By contrast, technology – the largest sector in global DM indices – has a much smaller representation in India's listed market, despite the scale and importance of India's broader technology economy. This gap has become more significant with the rise of artificial intelligence (AI). While India has strong technology talent and growing AI adoption, Indian markets offer little-to-no exposure to technology in the investible equity market. As a result, investors with portfolios concentrated in Indian equities have limited exposure to global technology leaders. Adding DM equities, therefore, provides sector diversification, including greater participation in the growth opportunities associated with AI, as well as geographic diversification.

Fig. 4

Looking beyond India expands sector exposure

Sector exposure of the MSCI World and MSCI India indices as of 31 August 2026



Source: FactSet, Standard Chartered



Argument

03

Market cycles are not synchronised

Indian equities respond sharply to domestic catalysts: RBI rate decisions, monsoon outcomes, fiscal borrowing announcements and India-specific political developments. When these factors turn negative, they tend to affect domestic equity positions simultaneously. Global equity markets are not driven by the same catalysts, so a domestic Indian growth slowdown does not cause US corporate earnings to fall or other global equities to retreat. Adding a global equity sleeve means that not all equity exposure moves in tandem during a domestic downturn.

The same logic applies to bonds. Indian bonds respond primarily to RBI monetary policy, domestic inflation and India's fiscal borrowing calendar. These drivers are largely independent of the global rate cycle. An investor holding only Indian equities and Indian bonds has all of their assets exposed to the same set of domestic macro factors at once. A portfolio that blends Indian and global assets reduces this localised cycle dependency, spreading exposure across markets that follow different cycles.

Fig. 5

Different markets lead at different times because their return cycles are driven by different economic, currency and policy forces

Five-year annualised rolling returns of DM and Indian equities in INR



Source: Bloomberg, Standard Chartered

Why Indian assets still belong in every offshore Indian investor portfolio

The case for Indian asset exposure for offshore Indian investors – India stands out as one of the few major economies where 6-7% annual real GDP growth remains a credible base case through the end of the decade. For offshore investors, the allocation case is not built on growth alone, but on **four reinforcing pillars**: a structural growth premium unmatched among large economies; reforms that have improved the quality and breadth of that growth; a demographic dividend that still has years to run; and a digital public infrastructure revolution that is lifting productivity at population scale.



The growth premium

According to the International Monetary Fund, India remains the world's fastest-growing major economy. Real GDP expanded by 7.6% in 2025 and is projected to grow by 6.5% in 2026 – outpacing China at 4.4%, G7 economies at 1.6%, and EM and developing economies at 3.9%. This is not a one-year outlier. Apart from the Covid-19 pandemic shock, India has sustained a 6-8% real GDP growth range for much of the past decade, reinforcing its structural growth premium.

This structural growth is also reflected in equity-market performance. Since 2001, Indian equities have delivered annualised returns of 10.1% in USD terms, outperforming DM equities, which returned 7.5% annualised over the same period. This long-term track record reinforces the case for including Indian equities as a deliberate source of growth within an offshore investor's portfolio.

For offshore investors, there is a clear benchmark gap. A global equity benchmark allocation of around 1.3% to India materially understates the country's economic weight. India accounts for roughly 8.2% of global GDP on a purchasing power parity basis in 2025, which is significantly higher than its equity index weight. As Indian capital markets deepen and foreign ownership constraints ease, this gap between economic weight and index representation should continue to narrow, while rising benchmark inclusion can create a recurring source of passive inflows into Indian assets.



Economic and market reforms

India's growth story over the past decade has not just been about the pace of GDP expansion. It also reflects a series of market-oriented reforms that have strengthened the investment environment and made growth more durable and accessible to long-term capital. Examples include the Goods and Services Tax, the Insolvency and Bankruptcy Code, the Real Estate Regulation and Development Act and measures to deepen and formalise domestic capital markets. Taken together, these reforms have improved the structural competitiveness of the Indian economy in ways that show up in productivity growth, foreign direct investment inflows and market depth – not just in headline GDP numbers.



Demographic dividend

India's demographic advantage is a long-term structural tailwind, not a short-term population bulge. The country has the world's largest working-age population and, with a median age of around 29.2 (according to Worldometer's latest data), remains one of the youngest major economies. As more Indians enter the formal workforce, earn higher incomes and build financial savings, they can support a broader domestic consumption base, deeper financial intermediation and continued capital-market growth. The shift in household savings from physical assets, such as gold and real estate, towards financial assets reinforces this trend. Monthly systematic investment plan (SIP) inflows into mutual funds, which have risen from approximately INR 36.6bn in 2016 to more than INR 310bn in 2026, are a clear expression of this demographic and savings transition. They also create a durable, domestically-sourced demand base for Indian equities that is less dependent on foreign capital flows.

However, the demographic dividend is not automatic; its realisation will depend on equipping a growing workforce with employable, industry-relevant skills and creating sufficient productive jobs. India has made meaningful investments in this direction through the Skill India Mission, including vocational training, apprenticeships and courses aligned with emerging sectors. Sustained improvements in training quality, employer alignment and job creation will, therefore, be critical to convert India's demographic scale into lasting gains in productivity, income and economic growth.



Digital infrastructure

India's digital public infrastructure – collectively known as the India Stack – has built a low-cost, inter-operable rails system that is accelerating formalisation, financial inclusion and commercial productivity at a speed with few global parallels. Examples include Aadhaar for identity, the Unified Payments Interface for payments, DigiLocker for documentation and the Open Network for Digital Commerce. Together, these platforms are productivity infrastructure: reducing the cost of doing business, formalising the informal economy and expanding the addressable market for financial services companies, fintechs, consumer platforms and logistics businesses in ways that compound into earnings growth over time.



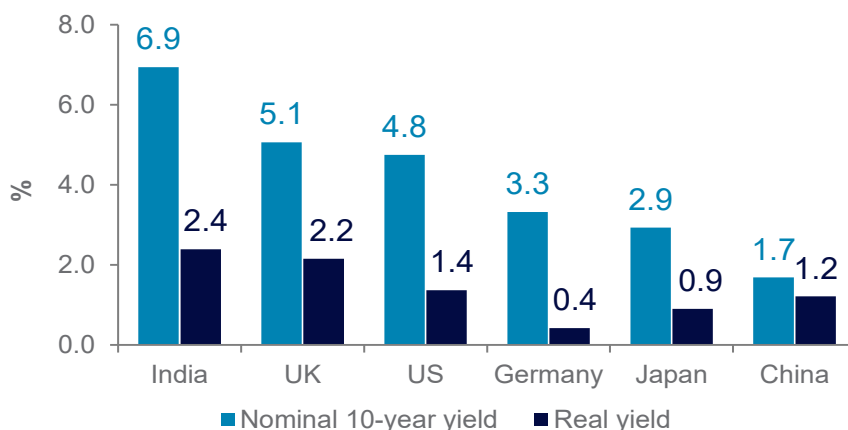
The India fixed income opportunity

India's 10-year government bond yielded around 6.7% in mid-2026, against headline consumer inflation of approximately 4.4% – implying a real yield of around 2.4%. This compares to near-zero or negative real yields in much of the developed world over the past decade and to real yields of 1-2% available in most comparable EM bond markets.

Fig. 6

India's real yield opportunity

10-year nominal and real yields of select DM and EM governments



Source: Bloomberg, Standard Chartered
Data as of 31 August 2026

The structural catalyst that makes this asset class particularly compelling for offshore investors is bond index inclusion. Indian government bonds began entering the JPMorgan Government Bond Index-EM Global Diversified Index from June 2024, reaching the 10% cap by March 2025. Bloomberg separately announced inclusion of Indian FAR bonds in the Bloomberg EM Local Currency Government Index, with phased inclusion beginning January 2025. These are not one-off technical adjustments; they create a recurring channel of systematic passive demand, as index-tracking funds allocate to India's sovereign bond market in line with its rising benchmark representation.

The portfolio impact

For onshore Indian investors, adding global assets can improve portfolio resilience without diluting expected INR returns. Our modelling shows that moving from a fully domestic portfolio to a 15% global allocation lifts the expected return only marginally, from 8.42% to 8.44%, but reduces expected volatility more meaningfully, from 18.38% to 16.86%. This improves the risk-adjusted return from 0.46 to 0.50. The benefit comes from exposure to markets, sectors and currencies that do not move in lockstep with Indian assets, helping reduce domestic concentration risk while adding access to different structural growth drivers.

Fig. 7

Adding global assets improves portfolio efficiency for onshore Indian investors

Portfolio allocations and statistics

INDIA Onshore	0% Global assets	5% Global assets	10% Global assets	15% Global assets
Cash	5.0	5.0	5.0	5.0
Fixed Income	40.0	40.0	40.0	40.0
Equities	50.0	50.0	50.0	50.0
Gold	5.0	5.0	5.0	5.0
Cash	5.0	5.0	5.0	5.0
DM IG Govt Bond	0.0	0.5	1.0	1.5
DM IG Corporate Bonds	0.0	1.5	3.0	4.5
EM USD Bonds	0.0	0.5	1.0	1.5
India Bonds	40.0	37.5	35.0	32.5
Developed Markets Equity	0.0	1.5	3.0	5.0
Emerging Markets Equity	0.0	1.0	2.0	2.5
India Equity	50.0	47.5	45.0	42.5
India Large-cap Equity	30.0	28.5	27.0	25.5
India Mid-/Small-cap Equity	20.0	19.0	18.0	17.0
Gold	5.0	5.0	5.0	5.0
	100	100	100	100
Expected returns (INR)	8.42%	8.43%	8.43%	8.44%
Expected volatility	18.38%	17.87%	17.38%	16.86%
Risk-adjusted return (INR)	0.46	0.47	0.49	0.50
Historical 10Y returns (INR)	10.27%	10.33%	10.39%	10.46%
Historical 10Y volatility	8.52%	8.30%	8.10%	7.92%
Risk-adjusted return (INR)	1.21	1.24	1.28	1.32

Source: Bloomberg, Standard Chartered

Note: Portfolio allocations are illustrative only and should not be relied upon as investment advice or used as the basis for investment decisions

For offshore investors with globally diversified portfolios, Indian assets are best viewed as a deliberate strategic tilt towards a differentiated source of long-term growth, rather than as a near-term portfolio efficiency trade. Based on our forward-looking Capital Market Assumptions (CMAs), increasing the allocation to Indian assets to 15% leaves the expected USD return broadly unchanged at 6.10%, while expected volatility rises from 10.32% to 11.00%, reflecting the additional EM and currency risks.

However, these aggregate estimates may not fully capture the opportunity in Indian financial market assets. Our CMAs show that the case for Indian equities is compelling when viewed from a returns perspective alone.

The challenge to portfolio efficiency arises from Indian equities' relatively high expected volatility. For context, our CMAs suggest an expected volatility of 29% for Indian large-cap equities. This number is considerably higher than the level experienced over the last 10 years (18.9%) and modestly higher than the level over the past several decades. This is a key point because the drag on risk-adjusted returns in Fig. 8 comes from the higher expected volatility of Indian equities rather than any challenge to the expected return.

As an example, Fig. 9 illustrates that calibrating Indian equity volatility to more recent market experience produces a more balanced assessment of portfolio risk and return. Using recent history as an example shows that risk-adjusted returns actually improve modestly from 0.79 to 0.81.

Overall, this means the debate is less about how high a return Indian equities are expected to deliver over the coming years. Instead, how volatile Indian assets are likely to be is key to whether adding them to global portfolios improves risk-adjusted returns.

Fig. 8

Adding Indian assets gives offshore portfolios a differentiated growth tilt

Portfolio allocations and statistics

INDIA Offshore	0% Indian assets	5% Indian assets	10% Indian assets	15% Indian assets
Cash	5.0	5.0	5.0	5.0
Fixed Income	40.0	40.0	40.0	40.0
Equities	50.0	50.0	50.0	50.0
Commodities	5.0	5.0	5.0	5.0
Cash	5.0	5.0	5.0	5.0
DM Govt Bond	17.0	16.0	15.0	14.0
DM IG Bonds	12.5	11.5	10.5	9.5
EM Bonds (USD)	10.5	10.0	9.5	9.0
India Bonds	0.0	2.5	5.0	7.5
Developed Markets Equity	44.5	42.0	40.0	38.0
Emerging Markets Equity	5.5	5.5	5.0	4.5
India Equity	0.0	2.5	5.0	7.5
India Large-cap Equity	0.0	1.5	3.0	4.5
India Mid-/Small-cap Equity	0.0	1.0	2.0	3.0
Commodities	5.0	5.0	5.0	5.0
	100	100	100	100
Expected returns (USD)	6.10%	6.11%	6.11%	6.10%
Expected volatility	10.32%	10.52%	10.74%	11.00%
Risk-adjusted return (USD)	0.59	0.58	0.57	0.56
Historical 10Y returns (USD)	7.60%	7.57%	7.56%	7.54%
Historical 10Y volatility	9.58%	9.45%	9.34%	9.26%
Risk-adjusted return (USD)	0.79	0.80	0.81	0.81

Source: Bloomberg, Standard Chartered

Note: Portfolio allocations are illustrative only and should not be relied upon as investment advice or used as the basis for investment decisions

Pulling this together, we would argue that a strong case exists for a measured allocation to Indian assets – particularly equities – exists, in our view, provided **two conditions** are met.

First, investors should retain conviction that the structural drivers of India's return premium – including earnings growth, improving governance and an expanding investable universe – remain intact. This is key to being comfortable with the expected return of Indian equities and bonds.

Second, investors must be willing and able to tolerate the volatility associated with Indian equities. While one could argue that the assumed volatility in our CMAs is high relative to the level experienced in recent decades, under most scenarios, it would remain meaningfully higher than that of DM equities.

Taken together, offshore Indian investors should consider incorporating Indian assets within a globally diversified portfolio. However, the allocation should be deliberate and sized in line with their objectives and risk tolerance, reflecting a conscious investment view and not just the familiarity of a home bias.

Fig. 9

Portfolio outcomes appear more balanced when Indian equity volatility is calibrated to recent experience

Portfolio allocations and statistics

INDIA Offshore	0% Indian assets	5% Indian assets	10% Indian assets	15% Indian assets
Expected returns (USD)	6.10%	6.11%	6.11%	6.10%
Expected volatility*	10.32%	10.29%	10.27%	10.26%
Risk-adjusted return (USD)	0.59	0.59	0.59	0.59

Source: Bloomberg, Standard Chartered

* Volatility for India large-cap equities and India mid-/small-cap equities is based on historical 10-year annualised volatility; all other assets use CMAs.

These results show that cross-border diversification serves different needs for different investors but leads to the same portfolio conclusion. For onshore Indian investors, global assets can help lower volatility, broaden sector exposure and provide a structural hedge against INR depreciation. For offshore Indian investors, India offers a deliberate growth and real-yield allocation that is under-represented in global benchmarks. In both cases, combining Indian and global assets can build a more resilient portfolio across market cycles.

Different starting points, the same destination

Resident onshore Indian investors and offshore Indian investors begin from opposite starting points. One is anchored in India and looking outward; the other is anchored globally and looking inward. Their regulatory regimes, base currencies and available instruments differ. Yet the portfolio destination is the same: meaningful exposure to both India and the world.

That conclusion reflects the reality of an interconnected investment world. Indian corporate earnings are shaped by global commodity prices, technology supply chains and demand from DMs. At the same time, companies in the US, Europe and Japan are exposed to the consumption growth of emerging economies, including India. Bond markets may respond first to domestic central banks, but they are still influenced by global rate cycles; gold is priced in USD, yet its impact is felt across currencies. No investor can afford to treat the other half of the world as irrelevant.

What differs is not the principle, but the path. The onshore Indian investor adds global exposure as a deliberate extension of an India-centric portfolio, seeking additional return opportunities while gaining a structural hedge against INR depreciation. The offshore investor builds India exposure as a deliberate overweight above global benchmarks, accepting INR volatility as the cost of accessing India's growth premium and real-yield opportunity. The appropriate allocation will differ by profile and risk appetite, but the core message is the same: **both investors need both markets.**



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Annual Wealth Check: Evaluating Your Financial Health

September 2026



WS Global CIO Office



A comprehensive guide to assessing your financial health and investment strategies on an annual basis.

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Chief Investment Officer, EMEA

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Portfolio Strategist

Many of us undergo routine yearly health check-ups to identify medical conditions early, initiate timely treatment and ensure or improve overall well-being. Similarly, an annual wealth checkup can help maintain monetary wellness and elevate financial outcomes. Reviewing your money situation once a year can help you understand whether your income, spending, savings and investments are still on track. It can also help you make small adjustments before problems become bigger. For example, research from a 2022 Vanguard report suggests that reviewing and rebalancing an investment portfolio once a year can help investors manage risk and capture potential returns, while keeping transaction costs lower than if they rebalance every month.

Our report serves as a comprehensive guide that can help you assess your financial health and investment strategies to elevate your monetary outcomes and achieve sustained financial success.

Importance of wealth checks

Financial health refers to the prevalent economic condition of individuals or families and their ability to manage their cash flows and investments. An individual's financial health takes into consideration their income, expenses, savings, investments and debt obligations. Ensuring robust and healthy cash flows promotes long-term stability and resilience. It can also help avoid unpleasant financial situations such as going over budget or falling into a debt trap. Some of the reasons to conduct a financial health check annually are listed below:



Ensure alignment with life changes

A Bankrate (2024) survey asserts that aligning finances with life changes is crucial to mental health. Around 47% of US adults indicated that money concerns have a negative impact on their mental health. Each stage of life entails unique financial concerns; for instance, 39% of millennials were anxious about debt payments and rising costs of living, whereas 30% of Gen Z-ers were concerned about their student loans and job market conditions. When financial decisions reflect your prevalent life stage and priorities, there is scope for improved decision-making and resource allocation. Being aware of one's financial situation often leads to intentional spending and adaptability. In essence, financial planning can become a technique to optimise personal fulfilment and not just a means to accumulate wealth. By aligning finances to prevalent situations and addressing challenges, the financial planning process can be transformed into a focused life strategy.



Track financial progress

The financial planning process begins by setting specific goals and aligning money decisions to these goals. It is important that individuals track their progress against the initial plan to ensure their wealth journey is on track. Conducting an annual review enables investors to calculate their net worth and gain a clear overview of their financial position, including their income, savings, investments, debt and needs for a rainy day. Over the years, this will also provide insight into how wealth has grown and whether financial habits remain aligned with long-term goals. Evidence suggests that individuals who track their net worth regularly are likely to achieve their financial goals comfortably and on time. This can be supported by making timely adjustments across different areas of personal finance, such as spending, saving, debt management, insurance coverage and investment allocation. Strong financial health is characterised by consistent growth of wealth with positive returns on investments over time, and healthy cash flows. Annual reviews can help ensure that one's broader financial plan remains aligned with personal goals, life stage and risk tolerance levels. Tracking financial progress also promotes more informed and confident decision-making.

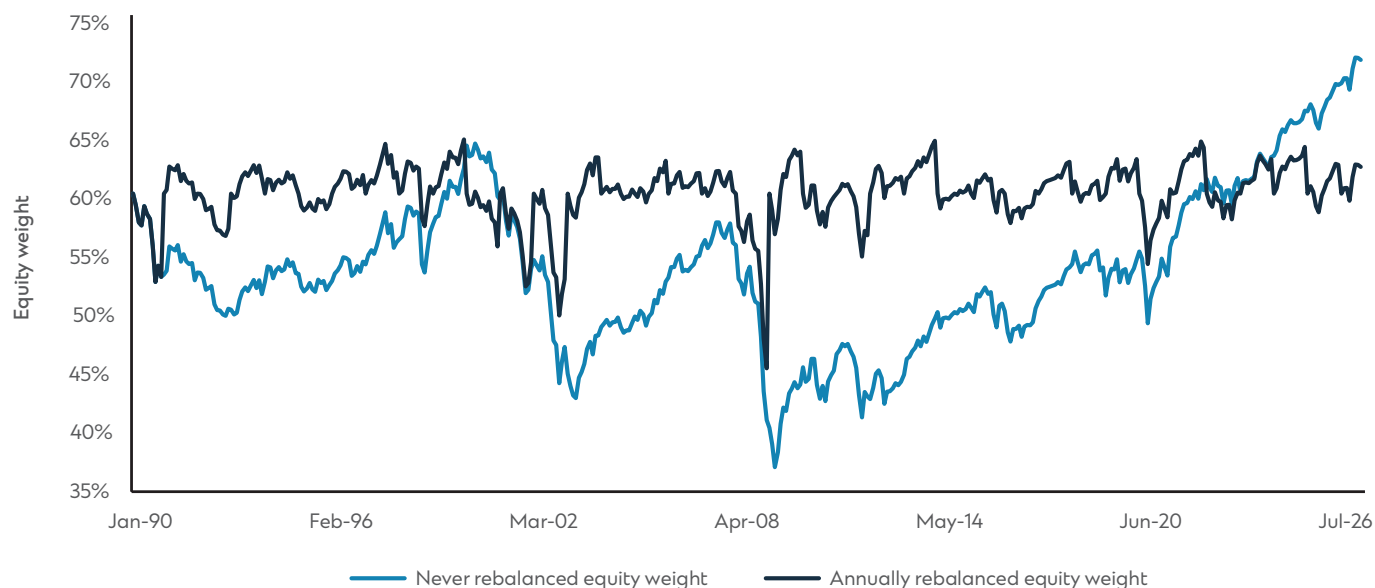


Consider risk exposures

Vanguard's 2022 report indicates that, by not rebalancing the portfolio regularly, investors may inadvertently increase their exposure to high-risk investments disproportionately. The chart below shows that a portfolio with 60% investment in equities in the year 1990, if left unattended, would have reached 71% exposure in equities by the end of July 2026. Periodic portfolio rebalancing should ensure that the asset allocation remains aligned to the goals and risk tolerance levels of the individual. In addition, such reviews help investors adjust their investment strategies to prevalent market trends, interest rates and economic forecasts.

Fig. 1

Asset allocations and risk exposures of a never rebalanced vs annually rebalanced 60/40 equity/bond portfolio



Source: Bloomberg, Standard Chartered

Note: The 60/40 equity/bond portfolio is made up of 60% MSCI ACWI, 40% Bloomberg Global Aggregate



Capitalise opportunities

Regular reviews allow investors to identify winning opportunities and increase allocation towards investments that can potentially generate outsized returns. These reviews also enable them to adjust portfolios to market trends and shift strategies to capitalise on emerging opportunities. For example, in current markets, companies operating in the AI space look promising, and an investor may benefit from buying stocks, mutual funds or ETFs that provide the relevant exposure. Many studies have established that optimal asset allocation contributes to over 90% of a portfolio's return. Contrarily, only about 7% may be attributed to stock selection and market timing. Regular reviews can help identify profitable avenues and adjust allocations to generate better returns.

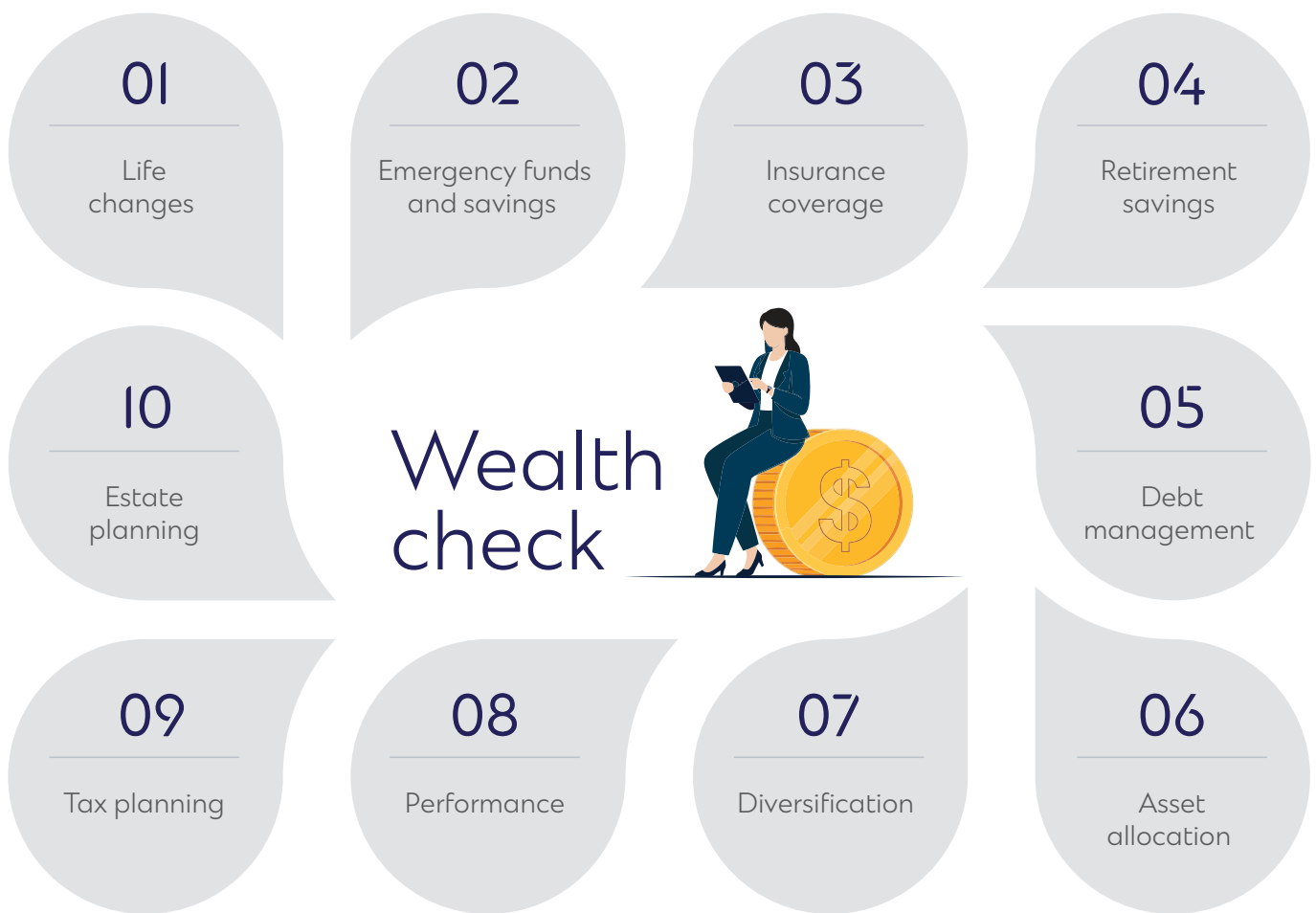


Financial health check-up process

Although the specifics of the wealth check process may differ based on the unique needs of the individual, you would need to include a few key steps to ensure sustained financial success.

Fig. 2

Components of a financial health check-up



Source: Standard Chartered

Analyse personal goals and priorities: Personal life events such as marriage, parenthood and a new job immensely affect financial goals and risk tolerance levels. The first step in an annual review is to assess the life transitions

that have occurred over the past year, as this will prompt changes in personal objectives, risk levels and timelines. For instance, once an individual becomes a parent, they would need to begin planning for the child's future education.

Address foundational aspects: The adequacy of emergency funds should be evaluated, and any shortfall should be replenished. The review should also ensure that the emergency funds are aligned to changing personal and economic circumstances. For example, after the birth of a child, household expenses would have increased; therefore, the emergency funds would have to be increased correspondingly. Although budgets are often drawn monthly or in line with one's income flow, spending patterns and cash flow may need a detailed analysis to assess if the budget is realistic. This investigation will also help identify impulse-led expenses and overspending bouts. Awareness about these patterns fosters accountability and enables better control over saving and spending objectives.

Check insurance adequacy: One of the most important elements of financial planning is insurance coverage, as it ensures a strong foundation and a sense of security. While insurance may be seen as a one-and-done process, it requires periodic assessment to align coverage with changing requirements. Annual revisions of coverage amount may not be necessary; that said, life events and other circumstantial changes may require strengthening the coverage. An annual financial health check should evaluate the insurance adequacy across life, health, property and other domains. Some suggestions on evaluation of insurance coverage are discussed below:

- **Life insurance:** Many thumb rules are used to assess coverage amount; one such rule, for instance, suggests a cover of 15x one's annual income. These methods, though, are quite crude and may not necessarily provide comprehensive coverage suited to individual requirements. At the start of one's financial journey, it is recommended that individuals conduct a detailed assessment on the coverage amount and customise the insurance policy to cater to the family's needs and

obligations. A financial health check should revisit the assessment to ascertain if circumstances have changed and accordingly make revisions in the coverage amount (only if required).

- **Health insurance:** As part of the annual check, examine the past year's health incidentals and the extent of out-of-pocket expenses. Evaluate the need for changes to the existing health policy to ensure enhanced coverage and reduced self-funding.
- **Property insurance:** Any new valuable purchase in the past year may need to be a part of property insurance coverage. It is also important to reassess the valuation of existing property, evaluate any emerging risks and adequately cover for them. For instance, digital assets may require cyber insurance coverage to protect against cyber vulnerabilities.

Examine retirement contributions: Retirement savings should also be evaluated continuously to ensure the corpus created will be able to withstand unique risks such as longevity and policy changes. As part of this exercise, investors should compare the current retirement corpus against the projected corpus based on their age and income. Any deviations (lower actuals versus projections) should be adequately compensated by increasing contributions. Individuals should aim to contribute around 15% of gross household income towards retirement savings, as this level can provide sufficient momentum for long-term wealth accumulation while preserving flexibility to meet other important financial goals; this will help them create a corpus that endures. Leveraging tax-efficient strategies (tax-advantaged accounts and strategic withdrawals) and diversifying investments can also help build a sustainable corpus over time.



Assess credit health: Keeping debt in check is integral to maintaining strong financial health. Without appropriate debt management, one can easily fall into debt traps. Credit health can be assessed using the debt-to-income (DTI) ratio; typically, lower ratios reflect strong financial health. DTI lower than 35% enables individuals to manage their finances comfortably and is considered a healthy ratio by lenders. It is also important to use credit cards prudently; they remain one of the leading causes of unmanageable debt among adults.

Evaluate asset allocation: An investment strategy can be aligned to market trends, personal objectives and risk levels after reviewing the asset allocation. Typically, the current asset mix is compared against the desired or ideal target mix, and any significant deviations are adjusted after analysing market conditions. As part of this effort, it is also important to reassess risk tolerance levels and adjust asset allocations as required.

Check diversification: A well-diversified portfolio is one that aligns with market trends and provides stable and consistent returns over time. Regularly reviewing a portfolio can help investors adapt to market shifts and position their portfolios well to capitalise on new opportunities while continuing to manage risk. As part of the diversification evaluation process, it is important to ensure that the portfolio avoids concentration risk and aligns with the investor's goals and risk levels. The process should also ascertain balanced asset allocation, mitigating systemic volatilities and optimising risk-adjusted returns. In evaluating a diversification strategy, it is important to understand cross-asset correlations and the changes that have occurred over the past year. Only a significant change in the underlying relationship between assets should entail a change in one's strategy.

Monitor performance: As part of the exercise, it is also crucial to assess all the money decisions and identify those practices that lead to better outcomes. The portfolio's performance is typically evaluated against a suitable

benchmark, and causes for any underperformance are identified. Take necessary corrective actions that can lead to optimal performance of the portfolio in the future. Investors may also need to evaluate other elements such as budgeting techniques and decision-making frameworks against suitable benchmarks. Identify areas that need improvement, such as excess debt, under saving or overspending, and make adjustments to improve outcomes.

Assess tax and cost efficiency: While taxes and costs may not be on an investor's mind, actively managing these elements can increase net returns. 'Tax alpha' refers to the potential value created by efficient tax management of investments. Strategies to achieve tax alpha include investing via tax-exempt or tax-deferred accounts and using strategic withdrawal techniques – for example, maximising contributions to tax-advantaged accounts. Efficient tax management can enhance after-tax returns by deferring and reducing tax liabilities, allowing more capital to remain invested and compound over time. The magnitude of benefit, of course, depends significantly on individual circumstances, including the taxation regime where you reside, marginal tax rate, portfolio structure and investment behaviour. Investors can look to implement a structured cost-benefit analysis to analyse significant expenditures and investments. This process weighs benefits against costs and taxes to determine if the investment or expenditure can elevate continued success.

Update nominations, wills and power of attorney: While it may not be necessary to update these documents every year, it is always prudent to go over these aspects. This will ensure that beneficiary designations are up to date, nominations and asset distributions align with current wishes and that the documents are legally valid. Any life changes always warrant an update of these documents. If executors, trustees or attorneys have been engaged as part of this process, it is important to evaluate if they can continue to act effectively.

Why annual review?

Multiple studies consider annual review of investments to be ideal as this frequency is a cost-efficient means to position the portfolio for new opportunities. Calendar-based rebalancing done annually works best owing to the following reasons:

It ensures alignment of portfolio allocation with risk tolerance levels. Unattended portfolios tend to drift from intended allocations, leading to increased risk exposures.

01



Annual reviews enable investors to harvest high-performing assets and buy undervalued investments, thus capturing market gains and maintaining desired risk levels.

02



03



More frequent reviews, such as monthly ones, can lead to higher taxes and transaction costs; by rebalancing annually, investors can harvest substantial risk premiums against relatively lower costs and taxes.

Common pitfalls

Establishing a routine-based wealth check to manage finances may become mechanical over time, and this can lead to mistakes that could reduce the benefits of this process. Some common lapses are discussed here:

Ignoring market cues

An investor's financial strategy should evolve along with the markets. Often, investors stick to an established investment approach that worked in the past, without considering market changes. This can lead to missed growth opportunities and reduced risk-adjusted returns.

Emotional investing

Emotional and cognitive biases drive almost 90% of investment decisions. These can lead to irrational decision-making that can produce sub-optimal results. Adopting a structured framework in decision-making helps keep one's emotions in check. Similarly, an objective review of the investor's financial health to inspect elements within the wealth landscape and thus gain actionable insights will promote an informed decision process.

Neglecting poor performance

Investors often tend to hold on to loss-making investments either in the hope that there could be a miraculous revival (loss aversion bias) or simply because resources have already been deployed and it no longer costs them anything to hold the asset (sunk cost fallacy). Both these behaviours weaken the portfolio's resilience. It is important to identify underperformers and weed them out before they become a sizeable part of one's portfolio.

Ignoring tax planning

Taxes command a large portion of our income, yet many of us ignore actively managing this aspect. This can lead us to lose out on significant savings that could have been achieved through strategies such as tax-advantaged/tax-deferred income growth and tax-loss harvesting. Overlooking tax planning can also lead to investors being underprepared for potential tax law changes.

Conclusion

Financial health checks serve as progress markers in an investor's wealth journey. If investors deviates from their intended route, these checks can steer them back on track and help maintain and enhance their wealth. Annual checks are a cost-effective means to identify areas for improvement and make necessary adjustments to investment strategies for continued financial success. It is important that this structured review process provides actionable insights that elevate money outcomes. Such a proactive approach helps investors adapt to evolving market conditions/life changes and position themselves well to capitalise on new opportunities and mitigate emerging risks.

An annual wealth check will empower investors to stay in control of their financial future and foster a sense of security.



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